

Chapter 2 Activity: AI Prompt Comparison

Prompt 1 Provided

How do I write a professional email?

AI Response

Writing a professional email doesn't have to feel like decoding ancient hieroglyphics. Whether you are emailing a boss, a client, or a potential employer, the goal is always the same: **be clear, concise, and respectful of their time.**

Here is the ultimate anatomy of a perfect professional email, broken down from top to bottom.

1. The Subject Line (The Hook)

Keep it short, specific, and action-oriented. People should know exactly what the email is about before they even open it.

- **Bad:** *Question* or *Hey*
- **Good:** *Project Alpha Update: Q3 Timeline* or *Meeting Request: Marketing Strategy*

2. The Salutation (The Greeting)

Start with a professional greeting. Unless you are on very casual terms, skip the "Hey guys" or "Yo."

- **Safe bets:** *Dear [Name],* or *Hi [Name],*
- **If you don't know the person:** *Hello [Team Name],* or *Dear Hiring Manager,*

3. The Opening (The Context)

If you don't know the person well, give a quick line of context. If you do, a brief, polite phrase is fine—but don't spend three paragraphs asking about their weekend.

- *"I hope you're having a great week."*
- *"I'm reaching out regarding the contract we discussed yesterday."*

4. The Body (The Core Message)

Keep it scannable. People skim emails. State your purpose quickly, use short paragraphs (2–3 sentences max), and utilize bullet points for details.

Pro-Tip: If you need them to do something, make the **Call to Action (CTA)** incredibly obvious.

5. The Sign-off & Signature

Close professionally and leave no doubt about who you are.

- **Professional Closings:** *Best regards, Sincerely, or Thank you,*
- **Your Signature:** Include your full name, title, company, and a link to your portfolio or phone number if relevant.



Putting It All Together: A Quick Template

Here is how a standard professional email looks in action:

Subject: Request for Project Feedback: Website Redesign

Hi Sarah,

I hope your week is going well.

The design team has finished the initial mockups for the new homepage layout. We would love to get your input before we move into the development phase.

Could you please review the attached PDF and share your thoughts on:

- The new color palette
- The placement of the primary CTA button
- The navigation menu structure

If possible, please send over your feedback by **Thursday at 4:00 PM**. If you'd prefer to jump on a quick 10-minute call to discuss, you can book a time on my calendar [here].

Thank you for your time!

Best regards,

Alex Rivera

Lead UX Designer | TechCorp

Quick Checklist Before You Hit "Send"

- ☐ **Proofread:** Spelling errors can make a great message look sloppy.
- ☐ **Check the attachments:** Did you actually attach the file you mentioned?
- ☐ **Double-check the recipient line:** Make sure you aren't accidentally hitting "Reply All" or sending it to the wrong "John."
- ☐ **Tone check:** Does it sound polite and objective? (When in doubt, emojis are best left out of formal emails).

What kind of email are you trying to write right now? If you want to share a rough draft or the specific scenario, I can help you polish it up!

Prompt 2 Provided

Act as a business communication coach. I am a BYU Pathway student who needs to write a professional email to my instructor requesting a one-day extension on an assignment because I experienced internet connectivity issues. Write a polite email in about 150 words using a clear subject line, a respectful greeting, a concise explanation, and a professional closing. After the email, briefly explain why each section makes the message more effective.

AI Response

Here is a draft for your email, tailored to be professional, polite, and concise.

Subject: Extension Request: [Assignment Name] – [Your Name]

Dear Instructor [Instructor's Last Name],

I hope you are having a great week.

I am writing to respectfully request a one-day extension on the [Assignment Name] originally due on [Original Due Date]. Unfortunately, I experienced unexpected internet connectivity issues last night that prevented me from submitting my work on time.

My internet has now been restored, and I am actively finalizing the assignment. If granted this extension, I will submit it no later than tomorrow, [New Due Date], by [Time, e.g., 11:59 PM].

Thank you for your time, understanding, and dedication to our BYU-Pathway class. I appreciate your consideration of my request.

Sincerely,

[Your Name]

[Your Student ID Number]

[Course Name and Section Number]

Why This Structure Works

- **Clear Subject Line:** It immediately tells your instructor who you are and what the email is about. Instructors manage many students, so putting the assignment name and your name upfront saves them time.
- **Respectful Greeting:** Starting with a polite salutation and a brief well-wish sets a positive, professional tone before you make your request.
- **Concise Explanation:** It explains the "why" (internet issues) without over-explaining or sounding like you are making excuses. It focuses on the solution by stating exactly when you will submit the work.
- **Professional Closing:** Expressing gratitude shows respect for their time. Including your student ID and course section ensures they can easily update your grade book without having to look you up.

Reflection

The most notable difference between the two AI responses was how specific and useful each one was. The first response provided general guidelines on how to write a professional email, including common sections and tips that could apply to almost any situation. In contrast, the second response was tailored to my specific situation as a BYU Pathway student requesting a one-day extension due to internet connection issues. It provided me with a complete email that I could easily adapt and also explained why each section was effective.

The element that made the biggest difference was adding details. By explaining my situation and my goal, the AI generated a much more relevant and practical response. Including a subject line and the requested format also improved the organization of the response, but the specific details were what had the greatest impact.

This activity helped me understand Ada Okonkwo's approach of reading first and using AI later. Reading or thinking about the task before asking the AI helps me understand what I need. That way, the AI becomes a tool to improve my work, rather than replacing my own thinking and learning.